interviews during the campaign in Hindi, but they were all soft focus and singularly undistinguished. I would send mails to his office every week but did not even get the courtesy of a response. NDTV's plight was even worse. They were promised an interview for a third time soon after the Times Now interview, only to have it cancelled again, at 3 the night before. 'It was all very unfortunate and, frankly, unprofessional, if you ask me,' Barkha told me later.

I later asked a Congress media manager why it went so horribly wrong. He said, 'Well, you see we thought that if we gave an interview to a tough interviewer like Arnab and got full coverage across the Times of India group which is the largest in the country, then we would establish Rahul as a politician who was open to public scrutiny unlike Modi who walked out of interviews. I guess we just didn't know how badly Rahul would end up looking.'

Yes, Rahul had botched up big time. When he should have come out looking firm, candid and wise, he had ended up looking unsure and inexperienced, a bit like a nervous batsman on his debut. As the advertisement jingle went, *'Pappu paas nahi hua!'* It was now time for Modi to show his young rival how it was done.

~

Ever since he walked out of a CNN-IBN interview in October 2007, Modi had been very careful of his public interactions. My Gujarati journalist friends in Ahmedabad would often complain, 'Modi treats us like crap. *Baat hi nahi karta!*' (He doesn't talk to us.) Though he did a few interviews during the 2009 and 2012 election campaigns (including the one on a bus with me), he had been circumspect in picking and choosing his moments. He had done an interview with Reuters in July 2013, which had stirred a fresh controversy. Asked whether he regretted the Gujarat 2002 violence, he had said it was how one would feel if a puppy came under a car wheel. The 'puppy' analogy led to his critics accusing him of gross insensitivity. Modi